

Part II — The Arrival

WHY THIS PART — WHAT IS HAPPENING AND WHY

Six figures arrive. The white working lights soften to amber — the "tenuous light" Pirandello specifies for the Six. The Door-keeper carries on the Boy-chair and sets it at the edge of the stage; the four live Characters — Father, Mother, Step-Daughter, Son — walk in behind him, the Step-Daughter already carrying the Child-bundle.

The Father asks for an author. The Manager, baffled, asks what kind of madmen have walked in off the street — and the argument begins: characters more alive than the actors who play them, Sancho Panza and Madame Bovary, *We want to live*. The Step-Daughter makes her case differently: two months an orphan, she sings and dances “Valentine” — cheeky, dated, wrong for the room — a provocation thrown from a wound. By the end of the part the Manager has stopped ordering them out and started asking questions.

The actors of the company, who began this part as bored professionals, slowly recede to the wings. They are now an audience to the spectacle that has walked into their rehearsal — and they keep reacting to it, dry and delighted, so the comedy never quite leaves the room. The lighting tightens on the family; the rehearsal room dims around them. But the laughs keep landing even as the family settles inside its own argument, with no author in sight. The comedy is what carries the audience into the drama, not what gets cleared away to make room for it.

THE SCRIPT, LINE BY LINE — WITH WHAT EACH LINE IS DOING

Caught between two identities, the actor inside the doorkeeper cannot quite suppress the dignity that makes the apology feel like a small act of resistance.

PLAYER 1 [*cap in hand — Player 1's diction still visible underneath*]. Excuse me, sir — *désolé* to interrupt; I know you don't like the morning's work disturbed...

Reflex authority: he hasn't looked up because nothing outside his rehearsal has earned attention yet.

THE MANAGER [*rudely*]. Eh? What is it?

The self-correction — timid hedge, then lifted chin — needs the Manager to know the failure was not his fault.

PLAYER 1 [*timidly — but not without a small lift of the chin*]. These people are asking for you, sir. I did tell them you were busy. They insisted.

Two targets, one breath: he scolds the door-keeper and pivots to the strangers without pausing, refusing to let the intrusion cost him a moment of control.

THE MANAGER [*without looking up*]. I am rehearsing, and you know perfectly well no one's allowed to come in during rehearsals! [*Turning to the **Characters**.*] Who are you, please? What do you want?

That hesitant 'actually' and the trailing ellipsis are a pre-emptive apology for a need the Father cannot help having.

THE FATHER [*coming forward a little, followed by the others who seem embarrassed*]. Actually... we have come here in search of an author...

He repeats the word back because repeating it is the only way to decide whether he really heard it.

THE MANAGER [*half angry, half amazed*]. An author? What author?

Any author will do — what the Father wants is not a particular writer but the function of authorship: a witness who will hold their story.

THE FATHER. Any author, sir.

Practical logic used as a door-slam, unaware it also names the Characters' deepest wound: no work exists, no form, for what they carry.

THE MANAGER. But there's no author here. We are not rehearsing a new piece.

She hijacks the Father's opening move and converts it into a commercial pitch, undercutting him and the theatre's self-importance in a single breath.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[stepping in front of the Father, taking the line]*. So much the better, sir, so much the better. You can put us on tonight — we'll draw better than whatever you were rehearsing.

Communal offence-taking bonds the actors together — shared indignation is easier than sitting with the grain of truth inside the taunt.

PLAYER 3 *[coming forward from the others]*. Oh — do you hear that?

The self-correction from 'perfectly' to 'adequately' is the whole wound: vanity punctured in real time, in front of his own company.

PLAYER 1 *[stung; it lands because it is half true]*. We were drawing perfectly well. ...Adequately.

Two negotiations running at once — he reaches for the Manager through logic while trying to restrain the Step-Daughter — and both are failing.

THE FATHER *[to Step-Daughter]*. Yes, but if the author isn't here... *[To Manager.]* unless you would be willing...

'Budget' alongside 'time' demotes the Characters' claim from existential to administrative: a bureaucrat's defence against the uncanny.

THE MANAGER. You are trying to be funny. We have neither the time nor the budget for funny.

His 'for Heaven's sake' is genuine horror at being misread as comic; the weight of the drama must be felt before any argument can begin.

THE FATHER. No, for Heaven's sake, what are you saying? We bring you a drama, sir.

A dare wrapped in a promise: she knows their story is dangerous and bets his theatrical greed will override his caution.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. We may be your fortune, sir — if you have the nerve for us.

Bundling them with 'our own' mad people accidentally concedes that a theatre is already full of controlled unreality.

THE MANAGER. Will you oblige me by going away? *Allez*, please. We haven't time to waste with mad people. We have our own.

He stops theorising and dares the Manager with his own trade: making invented things true is the actor's job — and the Six are already true; they lack only a stage.

THE FATHER *[stepping closer]*. You call us mad because we come without a book. But isn't that your work — to make invented things seem true? We are true already. We only lack the stage.

Applause as self-soothing: the company rescues its collective ego by cheering a speech about immortal works that sidesteps the mirror being held up.

THE MANAGER *[interpreting the rising anger of the Company]*. But I beg you to believe, my dear sir, that the actor's profession is a noble one. If today's playwrights give us stupid comedies to play and puppets instead of real people, remember — we are proud to have given life to immortal works on these very boards. *[The Actors, satisfied, applaud their Manager.]*

Agreeing so completely becomes an ambush — his embrace of their claim reveals that fictional characters are more honest than the living people in the room.

THE FATHER *[cutting across him]*. Exactly, perfectly. To living beings more alive than those who breathe and wear clothes — beings less real, perhaps, but truer. Truer because they cannot lie about themselves the way we can. I agree with you entirely. *[The Actors look at one another in amazement.]*

A knife slipped between the Father's ribs: she collapses his grand philosophy into the personal history only she was forced to witness.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[quiet, just to the room]*. Truer. He has been using that word for years. Ask my mother how true it sounded.

The Father has moved faster than the conversation can follow — a philosopher outpacing a room that still believes it is in charge.

THE MANAGER. What do you mean? A moment ago you were saying the opposite.

He pulls the abstraction back into reach: imagination makes the invisible visible — still pleading his existence, but now in words a listener can hold.

THE FATHER. No, sir. I mean only this: you know better than anyone that imagination gives bodies to things that would otherwise remain invisible.

A small surrender disguised as pragmatism: he has stopped trying to evict them and is now, despite himself, following the thread.

THE MANAGER. Very well — but where does all this take us?

He strips the metaphysics to the bone — not a lecture but a plea: they exist, fully, and have only been denied a place to do it.

THE FATHER. Nowhere — only to show you we were born this way. Characters. Alive. And left without a stage.

Feigned dismay is the first crack of genuine engagement: he has begun playing with the idea even as he pretends only to mock it.

THE MANAGER *[with feigned comic dismay]*. So you and these other friends of yours have been born characters?

His proudest claim gets the room's biggest laugh — and the hurt shows at once: the drama he carries is offered to people who are still laughing at him.

THE FATHER. Exactly, and alive as you see! *[Manager and Actors burst out laughing; it lands on him — hurt.]* I am sorry you laugh, because we carry in us a drama, as you can guess from this woman here veiled in black.

Ordering them out is also an admission: he cannot simply ignore people who have already made ignoring them impossible.

THE MANAGER *[losing patience at last and almost indignant]*. Oh, enough! Out, please! Clear out of here! *[To Property Man.]* For Heaven's sake, turn them out!

For the Characters, expulsion is not an inconvenience but an existential threat — his repeated 'no, no' is almost physical resistance.

THE FATHER *[resisting]*. No, no, look here, we...

Shouting is all he has left; the rational argument has escaped him and only volume remains.

THE MANAGER *[roaring]*. We come here to work, you know.

Retreating into stiff dignity rather than admitting the Characters have genuinely unsettled him — the pomposity is the armour.

PLAYER 1. One cannot allow oneself to be made a fool of.

He draws the actors' own professional experience as his evidence: if they can inhabit fictional lives, why can't fictional lives seek bodies to inhabit?

THE FATHER *[determined, coming forward]*. Your disbelief amazes me, gentlemen. Aren't you used to seeing the characters created by an author spring to life in yourselves and face each other? Just because there is no "book" *[Pointing to the Prompter's box.]* which contains us, you refuse to believe...

'Left stranded halfway' is the calmest and most devastating phrase in the scene — it names abandonment as a thing that simply happened to them, stripping away all self-pity, which makes it land harder.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[advances towards Manager, eyes level, not smiling]*. Believe me, we are really six most interesting characters, sir — left stranded halfway.

Two names that outlived their makers thrown against his own fate: finished characters live forever; the Six were made alive and then left with nowhere to be.

THE FATHER *[to the Manager]*. Sancho Panza lives. Madame Bovary lives. Their authors died, but they remain. We were born too — but left without a world to hold us.

Her 'many times' tells us the Father's grief has become a rehearsed performance for strangers — she has been his unwilling audience all along.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[low, to no one in particular]*. He has said all this to himself before. Many times.

'Quite all right' is exhausted concession wearing the mask of politeness; he has stopped fighting the philosophy and just wants a practical answer.

THE MANAGER. That is quite all right. But what do you want here, all of you?

Three words that compress the Characters' entire ontological need into something pre-rational — not to tell their story, not to be remembered, simply to exist.

THE FATHER. We want to live.

Sardonic as it sounds, 'For Eternity?' is his first genuine imaginative engagement: the absurdity has caught him before he can stop it.

THE MANAGER. For Eternity?

'Only for a moment... in you' is the most intimate request in the play — not an audience but an incarnation, asking actors to become vessels.

THE FATHER. No, sir, only for a moment... in you.

'As if there were room' is professional jealousy dressed as metaphysics — she is protecting her status, not making a philosophical point.

PLAYER 2 *[chin up, the diva back; sotto voce to Player 1]*. They want to live, in us... as if there were room.

He is losing control of the room and pivots to the Manager as his last practical authority — desperation dressed as organisational energy.

THE FATHER. Look here! look here! The comedy has to be made. *[To the **Manager**.]* But if you and your actors are willing, we can soon arrange it among ourselves.

The list of genres ends with honest self-deprecation about the revue, a brief human moment before he retreats behind gatekeeping.

THE MANAGER *[annoyed]*. But what do you want to arrange? We don't arrange things here. Here we play dramas, comedies, and — once a year, against my better judgment — a musical revue. Not whatever this is.

Structurally identical to line 48, the 'Exactly!' seizes any opening as confirmation, turning the Manager's dismissal into an unwitting invitation.

THE FATHER. Exactly! That is just why we have come to you.

A book is something he can hold, schedule, control — demanding one exposes the limits of a medium that cannot stage what has no material form.

THE MANAGER. And where is the "book"?

Asking the actors to trust the living body over the written text is precisely what actors dread and desire in equal measure.

THE FATHER. It is in us! *[The **Actors** laugh.]* The drama is in us, and we are the drama. We are impatient to play it. Our inner passion drives us on to this.

The aside curdles into attack: she picks up his word, crosses behind him, and hands 'passion' back with a hand on his shoulder — naming what he did while the room thinks she is being witty.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[without looking at him]*. His passion. Always the word *passion*. *[crossing behind the Father, voice flat]* My passion, sir. Ah, if you only knew — my passion for *him*. *[Places a deliberate hand on the **Father's** shoulder, leaves it there one beat too long, withdraws. A single short laugh — no warmth in it.]*

Fear of exposure, not moral outrage: her cold laugh dismantles the philosophical dignity he has spent the whole scene constructing.

THE FATHER *[angrily]*. Behave yourself! And please don't laugh in that fashion.

| A controlled detonation — she announces her orphan status and immediately punctures its pathos with cabaret, refusing to let anyone pity her.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. With your permission, gentlemen, I, who am a two months' orphan, will show you how well I can dance and sing. *Don't worry — it isn't a hymn. [Sings and then dances Valentine — bright, knowing, the smile a fraction too wide. Not a cabaret turn for its own sake but a provocation thrown by someone two months orphaned and lately for sale, daring the room to enjoy her. The audience should laugh, and then, a beat later, wish they had not.]*

| Entertainment has overridden judgment: the theatre's reflex to spectacle makes them forget, for one unguarded moment, that they were contemptuous.

PLAYER 1, PLAYER 2 & PLAYER 3. Bravo! Well done! Encore!

| His alarm at her sanity is really alarm at his own response — he wants order restored precisely because the song nearly worked on him.

THE MANAGER. Silence! This isn't a café concert, you know! *[Turning to the **Father** in consternation.]* Is she mad?

| Conceding what he cannot explain, the Leading Man lets theatrical metrics slip away and simply admits she has something he cannot measure.

PLAYER 1 *[to Player 2, won over].* She can hold a stage. I'll say that.

| Madness would be a mercy — the Father refuses it because the safer category would let her stop being right.

THE FATHER. Mad? No, she's worse than mad.